Revision of Black Dog, page 4

The firelight crackled against the desert's chill, Mouser crouching low, his fingers tracing patterns in the dirt. His voice cut through the hum of desert crickets. "There are noblemen, and there are noble men. Hazzan is neither." He tilted his head, his gaze flicking to Balthazar like a blade. "He names himself Hazzan. It's a name reserved only for Haz royalty. But we know he's a desert rat just like us, Brother. What's he getting at? We need to know what the man truly wants." I like this new tone - leans into "world slang"

Balthazar shifted his weight, the leather of his armor creaking faintly. His tongue caught on silence. I like these lines

Mouser didn't wait for an answer. He straightened and dusted his hands, speaking as though the night itself were his audience. "You haven't asked him. No matter. Here's what you'll do—stay close, but not too close. Wait. Let him fatten you with trust. Then, after wine and meat have dulled his edge, ask, 'Master, where to next?' You trust me, don't you, Good Balthazar?"

Balthazar's jaw tightened, but he nodded. Mouser smiled, thin and fleeting, before slipping into the shadows like an afterthought. this one too

The feast unraveled with wild energy, spilling into the cool night like a storm breaking its banks. The air was thick with roasting flesh and sharp spices, and the rhythms of drums wove into the chants of men swollen with victory. The black hound prowled through the chaos, its eyes gleaming gold in the firelight.

Hazzan was a thundercloud at the center of it all, his laughter rolling loud and heavy as he raised his goblet high. The fighters cheered as wine foamed over the rim,

streaking his arm like blood. Dancers spun through the fray, their veils falling like the last shreds of modesty.

these two paragraphs are a good example of using figurative language, setting scene, but also moving quickly. I know this is one of your concerns with description (as it is mine) so I think it's good to recognize the technical moves we make when we do achieve quickness.

Balthazar stood at the edge, his hands at his sides, fingers twitching. He was not part of this. Not quite. The hound brushed his leg, and he looked down, grounding himself in its presence. Then Hazzan's voice boomed over the din, a command that carried heat and gravity.

"Balthazar! My boy, come!"

choose one. I say "blooming" because it's more unusual

Balthazar stepped forward, the laughter of the tent swelling and blooming around him. Hazzan caught him in a rough embrace, the stink of wine pouring from his breath. The older man staggered on his feet and Balthazar braced him in the seat.

"Master Hazzan, steady now, Balthazar is here." Balthazar began.

"You're a boon Balthazar!" Hazzan laughed and swerving a goblet like a baton.

Steady, despite the tightness in his chest, Balthazar asked, "Where do we go from here?"

Hazzan froze for a beat, his lips curling into something between a grin and a snarl. "To the stars, my son!" he roared, throwing his goblet to the floor, its contents darkening the sand.

I like this contrast, more than how the first version played this line

The fighters echoed him, their voices ragged with wine and battle lust. "To claim the heavens themselves!" "Its deed has my name on it!" "What keeps us from its gates are merely the days!" They howled.

Hazzan's arm coiled tighter around Balthazar, pulling him closer until the wine on his breath was all Balthazar could taste. "Son," he murmured, low and thick, "soon, the tribes will kneel, and we will reign as kings."

Balthazar lowered his head, his hair falling like a veil to mask the doubt in his eyes. “And there will be more fighting?”

Hazzan tilted his head, studying the man like a curious predator. “You enjoy it, don’t you? It feeds you. I can see it.”

“I do, sir,” Balthazar said, his words clipped, almost reluctant.

Hazzan’s eyes narrowed, catching the flicker of hesitation like prey in a trap. “What is it, then? Speak.”

Balthazar hesitated, the words snagging in his throat before breaking loose. “Master, when will the fighting stop?”

Hazzan’s laughter came softer this time, a rumble that vibrated through his chest. “Tired already?”

“No,” Balthazar answered quickly, his gaze dropping to the floor. “But my brother—there’s no place for him in this world.”

The air shifted, the din of the feast pressing at the edges of the moment. Hazzan leaned back, appraising him with a slow, deliberate sweep of his eyes. “Then we carve a place for him,” he said, pressing a goblet into Balthazar’s hands. “Or we take it. That is the way.”

The hound growled low at Balthazar’s feet, and the firelight danced in his eyes. He tightened his grip on his goblet, the weight of it anchoring him as the stars swirled above.

I still do feel like I’m in medieval times in this scene.That past/ future aspect we talked about. Is there anything futuristic, image-wise, object-wise, that might be part fo this scene so we aren’t just “repeating the past” Even just what they wear, eat, drink out of?

A new chapter from Hassan that traces the beginning of a character named Bruce. In the chronology of the story, he is the last main character on Earth before the story moves to Hassan many years in the future and the ancestor of humans on Hassan. First draft.

Chapter: It begins with Bruce

The man who would become the Bodhisattva and later the *Machine Prophet* upon his death was born a week after a frigid Thanksgiving at the premier Women's Hospital in San Francisco. It was the Year of the Metal Dragon. Born premature at five pounds six ounces, Bruce entered the world the natural way. His mother, Grace, watched him with clenched fists and unblinking eyes as the nurse cleaned him after delivery.

His mother/Grace (for clarity)

She reached out. "Give him to me."

"Ma'am, it's unsafe for the baby; we need to take him to…"

"cheese" is a result of something being too common; these both are. Even just saying "Give him to me," Grace repeated, and she could feel the ice in her breath gets you out of cheese

"Give him to me," she repeated, her breath icy, her eyes unyielding.

The nurse hesitated, glancing nervously at the doctor, who whispered something in her ear. Stiffening, the nurse turned back.

"I suppose just for a moment," the doctor said with a rehearsed grin, too unsmiling to be sincere. He placed a steadying hand on the nurse's shoulder. Grace's hands shook as she took her son, cradling him to her chest. She rested his tiny head against her shoulder, cupping his delicate fingers with her warm hands.

I think here, the need for an adjective every time created the "cheese" take one of the following out: tiny, delicate, warm. I choose "warm"

maybe its just me, but even a construction like “and her voice trembled”reducers cheese. Why?
Because now the imagery is grounded in her as an embodied character more. Her body is doing stuff; it’s more gestural; versus the sense of narration from outside.
in effect, its just a slightly closer third person (let’s talk about this)

“Bruce,” she whispered, her voice trembling. “Bruce. It means you are strong, Bruce. My little Brucie Boo.” She said his name with a desperation to anchor him in the world. “Hello, hello,” she said softly. The baby’s shallow breaths calmed in her arms.

“Ma’am, we have to take him to incubation now,” the nurse said, her voice taut with unease. She fidgeted, casting uncertain glances at the doctor.

“Ms. Harlow…” said the doctor.

Bruce Lee?

“Mrs. Lee,” Grace correct the doctor, her full lips pale and tight from exhaustion tightened into a line. “You’re not taking him.”

“Mrs. Lee,” the doctor interjected, his tone firm but calm, “Bruce needs to be in the incubation unit. It’s critical for his health.”

“How do I know you won’t lose him?” Grace snapped.

good

“That has never happened here,” the doctor said, his voice calm but rehearsed, as he secured a coded cuff around the baby’s ankle. The device beeped softly, a sterile reassurance. He motioned to the nurse, who hesitated.

“Why can’t he stay with me?” Grace asked, her arms tightening around Bruce.

The doctor shifted, glancing at the nurse. “This is a critical stage. He needs the incubation room to stay healthy. You’ll be able to see him there as soon as you’re ready.”

Grace’s jaw tightened. “Then bring an incubator here.”

The nurse’s eyes darted to the doctor, who sighed. “We don’t have a mobile unit available,” he said, rubbing the back of his neck. His gaze flickered to the clock above the door.

good

I like this because the setting gets involved, not just their bodies.

“Richest hospital, and no equipment?” Grace murmured, kissing Bruce’s forehead as she rocked him gently. Her voice softened as she spoke to the baby. “You both look so nervous. What did my husband say?”

The nurse froze mid-step, her breath hitching.

The doctor cleared his throat. “Mr. Lee said—”

“My husband,” Grace corrected the doctor again, her eyes not leaving Bruce.

“Your husband said to keep you safe,” the doctor said, his tone firmer now, “and that’s what we’re trying to do. But every minute we delay puts Bruce’s health in jeopardy.”

Grace’s gaze locked onto his, cold and unrelenting. The doctor swallowed hard and shifted his weight.

“Quick,” Grace said, turning to the nurse. “Hand me my lipstick. It’s in my bag.”

The nurse hesitated, her hands fluttering nervously. At the doctor’s sharp nod, she rushed to the handbag, unclasping the gold buttons. Her fingers brushed against cold metal. She froze, her breath shallow, as the gleam of a small pistol caught the light. She pushed it aside gingerly, her fingers trembling as they rummaged past a stack of cash and a passport to find the lipstick nestled in the lining.

I think you could cut this

cut a couple of the body descriptors

With two brisk steps, she returned to Grace’s side. Grace unscrewed the lipstick, twisting out the bullet of pigment. Bruce began to cry, his tiny body trembling against her chest.

“It’s okay, baby,” Grace cooed, her touch soft as she marked his heel with a smear of red. She kissed him once more, her lips lingering, then handed him to the nurse.

The doctor draped a towel over Bruce and smiled faintly. “Rest now, Mrs. Lee. Nurse B. will be here if you need anything. We’ll take good care of Bruce.”

Grace said nothing, her eyes following them as they left the room.

In the hallway, the nurse clutched Bruce tightly, her knuckles white. “She had a gun! The psycho!” she hissed. “In a hospital!”

The doctor’s steps quickened. “And I wanted out of there as fast as I could.”

“Why did you let her hold him for so long? That was dangerous—”

“You don’t understand,” the doctor said, his voice low. “Do you know who her husband is?”

“Mr. Lee?”

“Titan Lee.”

The nurse faltered, her breath catching. “The industrialist?” Her voice dropped to a whisper. “That’s Grace Harlow… the prostitue?”

“Socialite,” the doctor muttered. “And one of his “wives”.”

“And this is his baby?”

The doctor nodded, his hand brushing sweat from his brow. “Keep moving,” he said, his voice sharp. “We forgot the basket.” He cursed. “This is bush league.”

They rounded the final corner to the incubation ward. The glowing sign seemed brighter in the silence. Inside, an attendant rolled out a trolley, a medical drone hovered near. The nurse gently placed Bruce into the incubation tube, her hands steady despite her agitation. The drone moved in, its metallic arms unfolding with a delicate efficiency. One arm adjusted Bruce with a soft grip, while another secured his tiny body in place. A faint hiss sounded as the lid slid closed, sealing the tube with a soft click. The drone

retracted, its limbs folding neatly as it hovered away, leaving Bruce enclosed in the gentle glow of the tube.

"Thanks," the attendant said, glancing at the doctor. "You okay, Bart? You're paler than usual."

a little confusing. The drone attendant? At first I thought this was the nurse, since they said "Thanks". Why would they be thanking the doctior?

ok - I'm not getting it

The doctor did not return the joke. They watched as the machine wheeled the tube toward the auto-rotation racks, its green status light blinking to life. The nurse exhaled sharply, her breath fogging the cold glass of the window for an instant before fading.

good, mixed description

maybe too much. Too much on breath & voice & hands in this section

"So… where's the dad?" she asked, her voice echoing softly in the sterile silence.

The doctor let out a long breath, his shoulders sagging as if releasing a burden. "I need a smoke," he muttered, his eyes fixed on the baby now sealed within the honeycomb. His hand drifted to his pocket, searching instinctively, then stopped short. He dropped it with a small shake of his head and leaned against the wall. A slight pop of the small of his neck was more satisfying than it should have been.

interesting

The nurse reached into her jacket and slipped a slim tube into his pocket. "It's fake," she murmured. "I quit a few months ago, but it helps."

The doctor pulled it out, held it to his lips, and drew a deep, resistant drag through the filter, his chest rising, savoring the memory. The faintest smirk tugged at his lips before vanishing again. Through the window, Bruce's tiny foot twitched, and the nurse could see the small smudge of red on his foot. She folded her arms, her fingers rubbing against her elbows. The chill in the hallway seemed sharper now. "Bart, and the dad?"

“He was anonymous on the delivery call,” the doctor said, still staring at the tube, “then he left after the cry.”

The nurse glanced from the baby to the doctor. “And he didn’t say anything?”

Without a word, the doctor pulled out his omni-messenger and tilted the screen toward her. One line of text stood out, unpunctuated and uncapitalized: *nothing happens to my son*.

Her eyes widened as her gaze traced from the text to the shimmering emblem at the top of the device—a sleek, etched T that pulse faintly. Titan Corp. Her gaze flicked from the message to the doctor’s drawn face. “That’s it?” she whispered.

He pocketed the device and exhaled slowly, his fingers tracing the edge of the fake cigarette. “That’s it.”

The nurse hesitated, her gaze flicking back to the incubator where Bruce lay, tiny and still under the glowing light. The only one marked in the entire nest. “Alright Bart,” she said as she turned, “shall we get her ready to see him?”

who? the mom? or someone nefarious we haven’t met yet?

The doctor didn’t move. He straightened, smoothing the breast of his coat. “She won’t.”

The nurse froze. “What do you mean, she won’t?”

“The baby’s going to the father, right now” he said flatly, his voice devoid of the warmth he had used earlier.

I wasn’t tracking the doctor as “warm”

Her breath caught, and she felt the chill seep deeper into her chest. “She just--You can’t--”

“It’s not up to me,” the doctor interrupted, his tone curt.

The nurse wrapped her arms tighter around herself. “Cold,” she said under her breath.